INDIAN MARKET IS IMPORTANT DUE TO THE GLOBAL DEMAND FOR INDIAN TALENT: WES



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World Education Services (WES) is a non-profit social enterprise dedicated to helping international students, immigrants, and refugees achieve their educational and career goals in the U.S., Canada and beyond. Since 1974, WES has provided credential evaluations to over four million individuals from more than 200 countries. With the ever-increasing globalization of education and work, it has become imperative to understand and recognize qualifications and credentials.

Ms. Esther T. Benjamin, CEO and Executive Director, World Education Services shares her views with India Today during her visit to New Delhi.

Please share an overview of WES and what exactly is credential evaluation?

World Education Services, commonly known as WES, is a 50-year-old global organization dedicated to the success of international students and immigrants from all over the world. We evaluate academic qualifications from around the globe.

A credential evaluation is a report that compares educational qualifications earned in one country to those in another. People use it to gain recognition for their academic achievements when applying for jobs, further education, or professional licensure.

First, we authenticate and verify the qualification to ensure that the individual has indeed earned the degree. We confirm that the qualification is from a recognized institution and that the degree is accredited in the country where they studied. The second part of our work is what we refer to as equivalency. This involves comparing education from one country to education in the United States or Canada.

So, an academic evaluation or credential evaluation ensures that a qualification from one part of the world is understood and recognized in another geography.

What is the USP of WES and the reasons for its global success?

We have a very talented team of over 350 people located across Canada and the U.S. Many of them have been international students and immigrants themselves and bring both lived experience and deep subject matter expertise to our work.

Additionally, the data and knowledge we have accumulated from our work is significant. Our methodology is proven, rigorous, and reliable – an industry 'gold standard.'

We are tech-savvy, enterprising and constantly evolving, always bold and ambitious about serving our customers and staying focused on impact. And as a non-profit social enterprise, all our revenue is re-invested in the people we serve.

Can you share some of the emerging global trends in Education that you think will have a significant impact on the landscape?

1. Internationalization of Education:
This trend involves the increasing mobility of students studying outside of their home country and the growing number of partnerships between universities worldwide. We are seeing a rise in dual degree programs, twinning agreements, and faculty exchanges.

2. Online and Hybrid Education:
The transition from tradition al distance education to more flexible online and hybrid learning models has accelerated, particularly due to the pandemic. Students now seek more options in how and when they study, including a mix of in-person and online classes.

3. Comprehensive Learning Pathways:
Education is no longer limited to traditional academic degrees. Today, it encompasses vocational training, micro-credentials, professional licenses, and practical experience like internships.

How big is the India market for you, and what are the challenges and opportunities that you are identifying here?

The Indian market is incredibly important due to the global demand for Indian talent. The numbers speak for themselves—about 30% to 35% of the people we serve annually at WES are Indian graduates. Generally speaking, around 150,000 Indian individuals bring us well over 200,000 academic qualifications to evaluate each year.

Understanding India is crucial for us, including its education system and the aspirations of its young people and professionals.

Interestingly, we can rank institutions worldwide based on graduate mobility. WES data provides insights into the institutions from which the largest numbers of graduates are pursuing opportunities abroad. In the Indian landscape, the top five institutions for WES are Punjab University, University of Mumbai, Anna University, Gujarat Technical University, and JNTU Hyderabad. The ranking can vary slightly from year to year, but these five consistently form the top institutions for which we do academic evaluations.

How do you envision the next 50 years for WES?

The next 50 years for WES will be about continuous evolution and innovation in service of our mission. We need to stay attuned to the changing landscape and be ready to develop new solutions to address new challenges that individuals may face.

It is about maintaining a relentless drive to be bold and ambitious and drive impact to help others achieve their dreams and realize their full potential.